



Benjamin M. Statler College of Engineering and Mineral Resources
Lane Department of Computer Science and Electrical Engineering

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To whom it may concern,

I am writing to express my support for the proposed New River Gorge Heritage & Visitor Connectivity Mesh Pilot being developed by Ms. Carrie Kidd. I offer these comments in my personal professional capacity and not as an official statement on behalf of West Virginia University.

As Raymond J. Lane Professor and Chairperson in the Lane Department of Computer Science and Electrical Engineering at West Virginia University, and as a researcher in resilient power and cyber-physical systems, I view this pilot as a thoughtful and appropriate first step toward validating advanced, partially unexplainable AI models in a real-world, resource-constrained setting.

In my interactions with Ms. Kidd and in reviewing her materials, I have found that:

- The focus on a single Appalachian community and a tightly scoped pilot is a sound methodological choice for early-stage validation of complex AI models.
- The combination of location intelligence, mesh connectivity, and locally hosted AI services has genuine research merit, particularly for improving safety, resilience, and situational awareness in rural and hard-to-serve areas.
- The attention she gives to data governance, robustness testing with changing datasets, and safety considerations is consistent with best practices for responsible deployment of such systems.

This letter is not an endorsement of a finished product, but rather an acknowledgment that the direction, scope, and validation approach Ms. Kidd is pursuing are on a promising track for a potentially powerful technology. In my professional opinion, a small, carefully monitored pilot such as the one she has outlined is an appropriate and meaningful way to learn about performance, robustness, and real-world impacts before scaling.

Please feel free to contact me if additional information would be helpful.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads 'Anurag'.

Dr. Anurag K Srivastava
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